

"CHHATRAPATI SHIVAJI MAHARAJ IS THE IDENTITY OF ALL OF US...OUR GOD. PLEASE DON'T POLITICISE IT. I WILL APOLOGISE A HUNDRED TIMES"

EKNATH SHINDE
Chief Minister, Maharashtra

its recent welfare schemes targeted at women, youth and the aged.

The initial response of its leaders did the Mahayuti no favours. Shinde attributed the statue's collapse to gusty winds blowing at 45 kmph. Sena minister Deepak Kesarkar drew flak for his comment that "something good must come out of this mishap" as he sought a 100-ft statue to be erected there. Then, former Union minister and the BJP's Ratnagiri- Sindhudurg MP Narayan Rane and his ex-MP son Nilesh launched an aggressive protest when Aaditya Thackeray and Opposition leaders visited Rajkot Fort. Videos of the Ranes threatening and confronting Opposition workers and police officers went viral on social media. Even Mahayuti sympathisers like ex-Rajya Sabha MP Yuvraj Sambhajiraje Chhatrapati, scion of the Kolhapur royals who are Shivaji descendants, weighed in, saying how he had written to the PM on December 12, 2023that the aesthetics of the sculpture were not in order and it seemed to have been "undertaken in a short time and in a hurry".

With the issue threatening to blow up in their face, Shinde held an emergency meeting on August 29 to accelerate the process of rebuilding a statue. Deputy CM Ajit Pawar tendered a public apology and said the collapse must be probed and a new and grand memorial for Shivaji be built. On August 30, the PM himself apologised for the incident while speaking in Palghar. "For us," he said, "Shivaji Maharaj is a deity. Today, I am bowing my head in apology at the feet of my presiding deity, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj."

Unwilling to let go that easily, the MVA has kept up the pressure. At a protest march in Mumbai on September 1, ex-CM and Shiv Sena UBT president Uddhav Thackeray alleged that even while apologising, there was "*magruri*" (arrogance) on the PM's face. Senior Congress leader and ex-CM Prithviraj Chavan, too, thought little of the PM's apology. "Nothing substantive is being done. There was corruption in the grant of the contract and it was given to an inexperienced sculptor. The guilty must be punished," he demanded. The Sharad Pawar faction of the NCP also held silent protests across Maharashtra.

Meanwhile, structural consultant Chetan Patil and sculptor Apte have been booked for attempt to murder and culpable homicide. While Patil has surrendered, Apte was arrested late on September 4. And the fall of a statue threatens to presage the fall of the government. ■

ECONOMY

A REALITY CHECK FOR GDP

By M.G. Arun

Fears that India may be unable to sustain a growth rate of more than 7 per cent came true on August 30, when the first quarter growth numbers for FY25 were announced. Real GDP grew only 6.7 per cent in Q1FY25, compared to 8.2 per cent in the same quarter a year ago. The growth was the slowest in five quarters (the economy grew over 7 per cent in the preceding four quarters), and was below the expectations of several agencies, including the Reserve Bank of India, which had earlier pegged its estimations of Q1 GDP growth at 7.1 per cent.

Agriculture was the biggest dampener, growing only 2 per cent in the quarter under review compared to 3.7 per cent in the previous quarter. Experts attribute it to the vagaries of the weather, especially the impact of a heat wave in several parts of the country. But even the services segment, including travel and hospitality, which had grown 10.7 per cent a year ago, slowed down to 7.2 per cent this time. This could simply be in comparison to the high numbers posted during the post-Covid recovery of the economy.

Chief Economic Advisor V. Anantha Nageswaran sought to

REAL GDP GROWTH FELL BELOW 7 PER CENT, COMPARED TO 8 PER CENT IN THE YEAR-AGO PERIOD, THE LOWEST IT HAS BEEN IN THE PAST FIVE QUARTERS